

Taking a call

The earliest telephones had two sets joined by a single cord, connecting just two places. Now, phones are wireless and we can talk to anyone anywhere in the world. We can now even see the person we are talking to, thanks to smartphones and phone apps such as Apple's FaceTime.

Candlestick phone

- **What?** Candlestick phone
- **Who?** American Bell Telephone Company
- **Where and when?** US, 1892

The candlestick phone was the first stand-up telephone and one of the earliest models of telephone to be mass-produced. It featured a mouthpiece (transmitter) at the top of the stand, and an ear phone (receiver) that was held to the ear by the user during a call—similar to those seen on the Western Electric candlestick (right). This type of phone lasted well into the 1920s.



Later candlesticks, like this one, had a rotary dial.

Each button sends a different pair of sounds to the exchange.

Western Electric nickel candlestick phone, 1920s

Push-button dialing

- **What?** Western Electric model 1500
- **Who?** Bell Systems
- **Where and when?** US, 1963

The push-button phone had electronic keys for dialing a number and was far easier and quicker to use than a rotary-dial phone. Although it was introduced in the 1960s, it was not until the 1980s that most users had push-button phones at home.



A push-button telephone

Holes in this rotary dial make dialing numbers easier.

Rotary dial phone, 1930s



Rotary dial phone

- **What?** Model 50AL Candlestick
- **Who?** Bell Systems
- **Where and when?** US, 1919

Automatic exchanges had allowed people to call each other directly since 1892, but the rotary dial, introduced in about 1905, made the process simpler. Later, handsets became popular, which combined the rotary dial with a handset containing both the transmitter and receiver in the same unit.

